



MONTHLY UPDATE

Lesotho: monthly update, August – September 2026

Edition of 2026-09-02 • 26 systems and instruments tracked

Developments summarised from sources published between the beginning of last month and today.

SUMMARY OF THE MONTH • GOVERNANCE • ICT INFRASTRUCTURE • DPI • DIGITALISATION • CAPACITY • DATA • GEOPOLITICS

Summary of the month

Four cybersecurity institutions were stood up ahead of their statute. The ministry and the communications authority [launched an interim national computer security incident response team and the inaugural National Cybersecurity Forum](#), appointed a [first government chief information security officer](#) and began standing up a [security operations centre](#), while the Cybercrime and Cybersecurity Bills remain before the National Assembly.

Two builds and a platform followed. Project Kobong, a hydropower and artificial-intelligence data-centre scheme, [was approved and launched at a ceremony hosted by the US Embassy](#); a Maseru workshop [opened drafting of a national artificial-intelligence strategy and a data-centre implementation roadmap on 17 August](#); and the [National Single Window](#) was launched at Maseru on 24 August. Against them, a freeze on refugee identity documents is reported to have left families stranded and bank accounts frozen.

Governance

Strategies, plans and policies

The month's policy work is a strategy being drafted rather than one adopted. A [National AI Strategy is being written at the same five-day Maseru workshop as the data-centre blueprint, opened on 17 August by the communications ministry with the United Nations in Lesotho](#), and is distinct from the National AI Policy signed in June. The deputy prime minister's keynote asked for Lesotho's existing capabilities, safeguards, infrastructure, policy and human capacity to be settled before AI investment is scaled. No publication date, custodian, scope or cost is stated, and nothing beyond the workshop is on the record.

Legislation and regulation

No instrument was made, gazetted or brought into force in this window. [Reporting of the CSIRT launch](#) discloses that the Computer Crime and Cybersecurity Bill has been split into a Cybercrime Bill and a Cybersecurity Bill, both awaiting National Assembly approval, and the ministerial reference to a national cybersecurity strategy that the wiki does not hold.

Public debate and participation in policymaking

The state opened a channel for hearing what its digital services are actually like to use: a [public survey opened on 9 August covering access, usability, trust and skills gaps across online applications, digital payments and health and education platforms](#), run with the United Nations development programme as part of a digital readiness assessment. No closing date, sample target or commitment to publish the results is stated, so what it will settle is not yet knowable.

ICT Infrastructure

Connectivity

The incumbent operator [began selling managed satellite connectivity as an enterprise service on 26 August](#). For a landlocked country whose every terrestrial route to the internet crosses South Africa, it is the first international path that does not.

Data Storage

The Kobong Project was approved and launched on 31 July 2026 at a ceremony hosted by the US Embassy in Maseru, attended by the ministers of energy and mining, of information and communications, and of environment and forestry. [Convult Energy's chief executive stated capital investment of about US\\$6.2 billion](#); the government figure for the project was restated as M100 billion against the M98 billion [announced with the binding agreement of 4 June](#), with the dollar figure unchanged. The US Chargé d'Affaires described the investment as trade over aid. Construction remains targeted for 2029 and the agreement remains conditional on feasibility, financing, permitting and definitive agreements.

Separately, and with no stated relationship to Kobong, the state began drafting a data-centre policy of its own. A [five-day, six-ministry workshop ran in Maseru from 17 to 21 August toward a draft data-centre implementation roadmap](#), coordinated by the UN Office for Digital and Emerging Technologies with the Resident Coordinator's Office and joined by UNESCO, the ITU, UNICEF, the OECD, the World Bank Group and UNDP. It covers data governance, skills, compute, energy, cooling, financing and implementation choices, and builds on the artificial-intelligence, data-management and broadband policies the government validated in draft in January 2025. The workshop [opened on 17 August with the deputy prime minister's keynote, drafting a National AI Strategy alongside the blueprint](#).

Energy

The electricity corporation [states it has held supply availability above 99 per cent on the transmission network and around 95 per cent on distribution for the past years](#), attributing the faults that remain to an ageing network and to weather. The figures are the utility's own and the base holds nothing that tests them.

Cybersecurity

The [interim Lesotho National Computer Security Incident Response Team](#) and the inaugural National Cybersecurity Forum were launched in Maseru on 29 July 2026. The forum is described by the Lesotho Communications Authority as a standing collaboration across government, industry, regulators, financial institutions and telecommunications providers. The response team is thus operating ahead of its enabling statute — the Cybercrime and Cybersecurity Bills it would sit under remain before the National Assembly — and on no published timetable. The ministry also reported a first Chief Information Security Officer appointed across government and a national Security Operations Centre being stood up.

DPI

Data Exchange

Lesotho [launched its National Single Window at Victory Hall in Maseru on 24 August 2026](#), under a World Bank-financed competitiveness and financial-inclusion project. No agency coverage, transaction volume or phasing is stated.

Digital Identity and CRVS

A freeze on refugee identity documents is reported to have left [families stranded and bank accounts frozen](#). Where an identity system is the gate to banking, an administrative freeze is a financial exclusion as well as a documentary one; no instrument, affected count or review route is on file.

Digital Payments and Fintech

The national e-invoicing platform [went to nationwide rollout](#). Nationwide is the supplier's word: no taxpayer count, threshold, phase-in schedule or revenue-authority statement is held, so the base can record that the platform is being rolled out and not how far it has reached.

Registries

A sector got its own register. Lesotho [launched a National Farmers Portal, placing every farmer in a single digital registry](#). A farmer register is the base for subsidy, extension and insurance delivery, so what matters next is enrolment and what other systems it connects to. The record held carries neither: no farmer count, and no statement that the portal exchanges data with the social registry or any payment mechanism.

Sectoral management information systems

The national commission [advertised a consultancy to strengthen its capacity to coordinate national monitoring and evaluation reporting](#). A tender for the capacity to coordinate reporting is itself a statement that the reporting is not coordinated; no scope, budget or deliverable date is published.

Other GovTech and e-Gov

At the launch of the national response team the ministry [also stated a plan to move ICT services out of the civil service into a separate agency](#). No enabling instrument, budget, staffing or date accompanies it, so the plan is on record and the agency is not.

Digitalisation

Rural digital data capture

Two movements reached rural service points from opposite directions. Thirty [SMS-based birth registration stations were established in government and church health facilities across Maseru, Berea and Leribe on 5 August](#), putting the capture point in the clinic rather than the registry office and on a text message rather than a terminal. Days earlier the universal service fund [opened procurement for Wi-Fi and network equipment at police stations across all ten districts](#).

Capacity

Training and skills

MICSTI reported [digital-literacy training running across all ten districts](#) at the CSIRT launch on 29 July, with no participant numbers published.

Data

National statistics

The Bureau of Statistics [lists the strategy for 2022/23 to 2026/27 alongside the 2001 Act as its current framework](#). The strategy runs out in the coming financial year and no successor is on the record.

Geopolitics

US / hyperscaler activities

The [US Embassy stated](#) at the Kobong ceremony that it has facilitated US\$7.3bn of commercial partnerships in Lesotho over the previous eighteen months.

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